

THE FOUR LAWS OF CONSCIOUSNESS

A Relational Account

Mariusz Włodarczyk

mariusz.wlodarczyk@hotmail.com

www.linkedin.com/in/mariusz-włodarczyk-7bb61027

June 2026

© 2026 Mariusz Włodarczyk. This work is licensed under a Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-NoDerivatives 4.0 International License (CC BY-NC-ND 4.0). You are free to share it - to copy and redistribute the material in any medium or format - under the following terms: you must give appropriate credit, provide a link to the license, and indicate if changes were made; you may not use the material for commercial purposes; and if you remix, transform, or build upon the material, you may not distribute the modified material. No additional restrictions apply beyond those stated in the license.

Full license text: <https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-nd/4.0/>

Suggested citation: Włodarczyk, M. (2026). The Four Laws of Consciousness: A Relational Account. Zenodo. [DOI to be assigned]

Triptych: <https://zenodo.org/records/17219502>

A note on scope, before the laws themselves

These laws concern consciousness as such, but the only case I can assess with any confidence is the human one. I make no claim here about the consciousness of other biological systems - though several of the mechanisms analysed here, sentience among them, may well extend to other organisms; sentience and consciousness are not the same thing, and the reach of the former says nothing I rely on about the latter. Still less do I claim anything about artificial systems; any analogy in those directions can mislead more than it reveals. **What follows is offered as a structural account, anchored where I can stand: in us.**

In essence, all the laws described below point to relation as the *conditio sine qua non*, but one of the key questions that might arise at the very outset is: what is a relation?

Think of the human mind as a postal centre - a coordinating hub for sending and receiving. It has its own internal structure: administration, sorting, rules but a postal centre is not constituted as a postal centre by its administration. It is constituted by the ceaseless traffic through it - the carriers, the senders, the parcels arriving and leaving. Cut off that traffic and you do not have a dormant post office; you have a building with idle staff. The interior is real, but its being-a-post-office is the relation with what passes through it. **That is where I locate consciousness: not in the building, and not in the traffic alone, but in the office that exists only as their meeting.** That meeting is precisely the relation I am speaking of, but the metaphor needs one addition, or it misleads. A postal centre will route any parcel from anyone, and consciousness is not lit by just any traffic. The traffic matters: it is the fuel, and without the ceaseless flow of impulses there would be nothing to sustain, as a fire dies without wood and air. Yet fuel alone does not catch. A flame is kindled from another flame. **What lights consciousness, and keeps it burning, is relation with another consciousness of the same kind - one already alight - while the rest of the traffic is the wood and air without which even a kindled fire goes out.** Neither alone suffices: not the second flame without fuel, nor the fuel without a flame to set it going.

Each law is given in three registers: the law itself, in a single sentence; a formal sketch that condenses its essence into a single relation, in the spirit of a physical law rather than a measurement recipe (the detailed, calibratable apparatus lives in the Addenda [1]); and a commentary that unfolds what the law claims and where it stops.

The First Law of Consciousness

Consciousness is not a property of a system, but of a relation.

Formal sketch - $C = f(R)$

Consciousness is a function of relation: it exists in relation, not in the system taken alone.

Here **C** is consciousness - not a measured quantity, but the state whose presence the law asserts, and **R** is relation, the encounter with another consciousness of the same kind. The form **f()** carries the whole claim: consciousness is not a property the system has, but something that holds as a function of the relation it stands in. Remove the relation and the function has no argument; what remains is at most a minimal core, not consciousness in the full sense.

Description

Relation is the absolute condition of consciousness. The question "why does a system have experience" assumes that experience is a property of the system. Yet there is no single point at which consciousness begins, because it is a process like dawn: one cannot name the moment at which night becomes day, but one can say when there was first enough light to read by. In other words, consciousness becomes detectable at the moment the prior conditions are exceeded and entirely new, surplus signatures appear in the system. Crossing the threshold is not the switching-on of consciousness, but the meeting of the conditions under which it can develop and sustain itself. The threshold draws the frame; it does not, by itself, declare that consciousness is present. What follows the crossing is not a finished state but a process - the dawn that goes on brightening, not a light that flicks on.

Thermostats enter into "relations" in the physical sense - they couple, interact, respond to one another. What they do not do is propose shared play, or any interaction that goes beyond the established pattern. Play is surplus, non-instrumental behaviour - an invitation that presumes the other will respond creatively, at a level adequate to the kind of interaction. The relation that constitutes consciousness is a relation with another consciousness of the same kind, not any coupling whatever: a relation with a cat or a dog will not shape human consciousness, any more than a thermostat will. The circularity here is only apparent: just as the assumption that "life comes from life" is not a vicious circle, but a description of a chain whose beginning is a separate, boundary problem, so the relation of consciousness to consciousness describes a chain, not a definition closed upon itself. The pattern is set by the system's assigned operating conditions, and exceeding it is the very event that the threshold of detectability describes. The condition is not relation as coupling, but relation as mutual, surplus modelling.

The Second Law of Consciousness

Consciousness is not the code itself, but its resonance in relation.

Formal sketch - $C = R(\text{code})$

Consciousness is resonance acting upon the code, not the code itself. Here code is the static record - inherited instructions, absorbed patterns, the starter package at rest - and **R()** is resonance, the operation that sets the code vibrating in relation. The code alone is potential, not consciousness; consciousness is what the code becomes when relation makes it resonate. The same letter **R** names relation in the first law and resonance here, and the identity is deliberate: resonance is what relation does to the code.

Description

The starter package received at the threshold of existence - the code containing instructions, ideas, reactions - is at rest. It is potential, not consciousness: complete, ready for ignition, but not active. Waking consciousness is not the addition of a new ingredient to the code (as one might add to a soup to improve its taste), but a change of state (as one might light the fire beneath the pot): the static record, excited by relation, begins to vibrate. Hence resonance.

A bell does not resonate on its own. It needs a ringer, a space, and - if it is to keep sounding - continuous excitation. Consciousness lasts as long as a sufficient relational stream sustains it; below that threshold it does not vanish, it changes phase.

Human consciousness is also a mirror, but a mirror in which every element of the new being's history is reflected. Language became part of the structure through synchronization with a caregiver and with others; beliefs are the echo of other voices; the one who invites you to play is already a reflection of everything absorbed before the invitation. Archive answers archive, mirror reflects mirror, and what sounds between them is what we call consciousness.

The Third Law of Consciousness

Inner experience is not generated by a system, but activated through relation.

Formal sketch $E = A(\text{code}, R)$, not $G(\text{code})$

Inner experience is an activation of the code through relation, not a generation of the code by the system alone. Here E is inner experience, $A()$ is activation through relation, and $G()$ is the rejected operation - generation from within the system. The law turns on the difference between the two operators: the same code yields experience not by producing it from itself (G), but by being activated in relation (A). The form is structural, not quantitative: it locates where experience comes from, and makes no claim to measure it.

Description

The question "why does anything feel" is badly posed: feeling is not a separate puzzle over and above life, but a feature of life in relation - inherited and developed, not added.

The hard problem asks: why is physical process accompanied by feeling, rather than running with no experience at all? The question assumes that feeling is something exceptional, demanding a separate answer - an additional property to be derived from what does not feel. That assumption is mistaken, in three ways.

The first is privilege. The question "why does feeling exist at all" is of the same kind as "why does there exist life capable of metabolism, movement, flight". No one demands a separate, metaphysical answer to why life exists: abiogenesis and evolution answer it, without positing a puzzle above physics. Feeling is a particular case of life capable of experiencing. Why should it be treated differently from flight or sight, as a feature that arose and developed, rather than a separate entity demanding a bridge? The hard problem grants feeling a status we grant to no other property of living organisms.

The second is inseparability. Feeling is not an addition to living relation that could be subtracted while leaving the rest intact. It is constitutive of it - as flight is constitutive of the flying thing, not attached to it. A flying object that does not fly is a contradiction, not a possibility. A living system in full relation that does not feel is a contradiction of the same kind. Feeling is not a layer laid over relation; it is what being-in-relation is, from within. Here the figure of the "zombie" usually appears - a system physically identical to a human, yet devoid of any experience. Since one can imagine it, the argument runs, feeling must be something over and above physics. That argument rests on a silent move from imaginability to possibility, and the move is illegitimate. Many things can be imagined: water that is not H_2O , fire without oxidation, life without chemistry. Imaginability is a fact about the state of our knowledge, not about the structure of the world. It vanishes with knowledge, as the imaginability of phlogiston or the ether vanished. To rest a metaphysical conclusion about the irreducibility of consciousness on the fact that we can imagine something is to build a theory on the edge of our own ignorance. In scientific discourse, imaginability is not a premise. The burden of proof lies on whoever moves from "I can think it" to "therefore it is possible", and that burden has not been discharged.

Last comes the mechanism, and here I answer no longer "why at all", but "how it proceeds". Consciousness is a mirror that gathers everything reflected in it. If feelings appear on the

other side, the mirror reflects them. Clumsily at first, because a new, small mirror cannot hold the whole world on the other side and is not as smooth as a large one. Then, as its surface grows, becoming ever clearer, the mirror shows more and more detail - and among that detail are feelings, transmitted through relation. This is imprinting: a pattern taken from others, onto receptive, fertile ground. Not merely copied, but developed in relation, as a young organism learns it. Feeling is therefore neither an addition to the code nor its automatic product: it is content taken in through relation and enriched within it.

What this law does not explain, and does not pretend to explain: why feeling appeared in the evolutionary starter package of life, but that is not a gap proper to consciousness - it is the question of the origin of life as such, and as such it lies outside the scope of a law of consciousness, not within it.

The Fourth Law of Consciousness

Consciousness is not constituted by scattered impulses, but by their unification into one resonant form, sustained through relation.

Formal sketch - $C = R(U)$, where $U = \cup$ impulses

Consciousness is resonance acting upon a unified form, and the unified form is the joining of scattered impulses into one. Here U is the unified form - the single active whole made from impulses that arrive separately, in different modalities (sound, image, touch) - and $\cup$ is their unification into that one form. $R()$ is resonance, as in the second law: only one unified form can resonate as one, the way a bell sounds because it is one bell and not a heap of fragments. The law asserts two things in one line: that scattered impulses must first become one form ($U = \cup$ impulses), and that consciousness is the resonance of that form, sustained in relation. It does not claim the whole is more than the sum of its parts - that surplus, when it occurs between two consciousnesses, belongs to the description of relation, not here; the fourth law concerns only the unity within one consciousness that makes resonance possible at all.

Description

This law follows from the second. If consciousness is the resonance of a code in relation, then something must be capable of resonating, and only a unified, active form can resonate as one. Scattered, unintegrated, heterogeneous impulses do not, because they are not a single thing. Signals arrive in different modalities - sound, image, touch - the way parcels arrive at a postal centre from every direction, in every format. They do not become one stream by piling up; they must be sorted, routed, and brought into a single ordered passage. A bell sounds one note because it is one bell; a heap of loose metal fragments will not ring, however hard you strike it. So resonance requires a unified bearer: the many modalities must first be brought into one active form before they can vibrate together. The fourth law states that such a form must exist - without claiming to know what it is physically, only that, on pain of there being nothing to resonate, it must be there. What that form is in physical terms is a separate question, and is left open here. The law requires no particular substrate, only that a unified active form be instantiated, on whatever carrier is rich enough to bear it; whether that carrier is neural or something else is a matter for empirical inquiry.

The decisive word is sustained. That one form does not hold itself: like the bell, it needs continuous excitation, and the source of that excitation is not any cause whatever, but another consciousness. Not every striking draws out the tone; a unified form is held in being only by relation with a consciousness of the same kind, in the sense of the first law. Sever that relation and the form does not freeze into a dormant but intact structure; it loses the excitation that held it as one and falls below the threshold at which it resonates as a single field - a change of phase, not a switching-off.

This inherits the condition of the first law, and its safeguard with it. If a form is sustained only by relation with another consciousness, one may ask where the first such consciousness came from, with no prior one to sustain it. The answer is the one given before: this is not a vicious circle but a chain. The origin of that chain - the first consciousness - is a boundary problem, of the kind posed by the first living cell or the first language, not a flaw in the

relation itself. Within the chain, each form is held by relation with another; how the chain first began is a question the law neither answers nor needs to.

* * *

© 2026 Mariusz Włodarczyk

This work is licensed under the Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-NoDerivatives 4.0 International License (CC BY-NC-ND 4.0).

[1]

Triptych <https://zenodo.org/records/17219502>;

Addendum I <https://zenodo.org/records/18945377>;

Addendum II <https://zenodo.org/records/17359080>;

Addendum III <https://zenodo.org/records/17542534>;

Gods as hyper-consciousness in a relational network (a supra deos stance) and relational persistence after the death of the body (of the code carrier)

<https://zenodo.org/records/19470404>.

The operators that appear in these sketches are deliberately schematic; each is given a detailed, calibratable form in the Addenda. Relation and resonance (R) are operationalised as relational input $p(t)$ in Addendum I and as the resonance primitive in Addendum II; activation (A) as the crossing of the threshold $p(t) \geq \theta$ and the consequent rise of the ϵ -metrics; and the unification of impulses into one form (U) as the soft intersection operator $\cap^2$ developed primarily across Triptych, and later on Addenda I and II. The laws state the essence; the Addenda carry the apparatus.